

HISTORY LESSONS

In the Seventies, Roy Thomas became Marvel's first editor-in-chief after Stan Lee, making him the ideal candidate to write a new book about the company's 75-year history. We spoke to him about a life shaping the future of Marvel...

Thanks to Marvel Studios, millions of people are now familiar with characters that even just a few years ago would have been considered too risky for a film franchise. Those with a more established success record, such as Spider-Man and the X-Men, still command a following, and even creator Stan Lee has acquired celebrity status, with his signature film cameos and even his own convention.

Such is the company's appeal that US TV channel ABC recently screened a one-hour documentary, *Marvel 75 Years: From Pulp To Pop!* to honour it reaching an important anniversary, while book publisher Taschen has contributed its own celebration in the form of a 720-page hardcover, *75 Years Of Marvel: From The Golden Age To The Silver Screen*. A tome worthy of the famous 'mighty Marvel' moniker, it has been written by former editor-in-chief – and in the early Seventies, the first successor to Stan Lee – Roy Thomas, who tells its story from its humble beginnings in 1939 through to its major reinvention in the Sixties, right up to becoming the powerhouse it is today.



Helped by editor Josh Baker, Thomas has assembled nearly 2,000 photographs of vintage comic-books, original artwork, toys and collectables, as well as a four-foot fold-out timeline and biographies of key creators. Thomas' Marvel career began in 1965 as a writer, producing memorable runs on both the *X-Men* and *The Avengers*, with a hand in creating characters like Ultron, the Vision and Wolverine. We spoke to him about his life, career and Stan Lee.

Your book details 75 years of Marvel Comics history. How did it all begin?

It began with Martin Goodman, who published pulp magazines from around 1933, and switched to comics in 1939. The company was called Timely Publications back then, and didn't change its name to Marvel until later, but you can see the first use of the word on the cover of *Marvel Science Stories*, a pulp magazine from 1938, later called *Marvel Tales*. Goodman must have liked it because *Marvel Comics* #1 came out in 1939, and was the book that introduced the original Human Torch and the Sub-Mariner. It was a huge hit.

You were born in 1940, so do you remember those early comics?

From the age of about five, I started to become interested in comic-books, especially *Superman*, *Batman* and *All-Star Comics* – which featured the Justice Society of America – followed closely by *The Human Torch*, *Sub-Mariner* and *Captain America* at Timely, and of course *Captain Marvel* [Shazam], but I would read any I could get my hands on. By the mid-Forties, when I started reading, superheroes were beginning to fade out, so Timely had only kept the three I mentioned, but I am vaguely aware of others that it published, such as Miss America, and later Sun Girl, Venus and Marvel Boy.

So if superheroes weren't popular, what was Timely doing instead?

It was trying to branch out – it released a lot of funny comics, Westerns and then war comics in the Fifties. By then, the superheroes were mostly gone, but hardly missed, I'm sure, by the writers and artists in general. I do remember the first Captain America revival of the early Fifties, though, introducing him as a 'commie-smasher', and I loved it. I've always thought the Soviet-controlled communists made as good a set of villains as the Nazis.

Was your joy of comics affected by the general view in the Fifties that they were



Thomas at his desk at Marvel.